
Building the formation against a classical center

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HB-01 - This illustrative route shows the recognizable formation when White develops quietly. The knights avoid blocking the fianchetto bishops, but Black has used many pawn tempi and is still uncastled.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Decide on king safety and a central break. Examine ...c5 against d4 and ...d5 against e4; neither move is compulsory or safe in every version.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White owns more space and can prepare d5, e5 or a wing attack. Finishing the diagram is not a strategic achievement if Black then has no active move.

RECOGNITION TEST

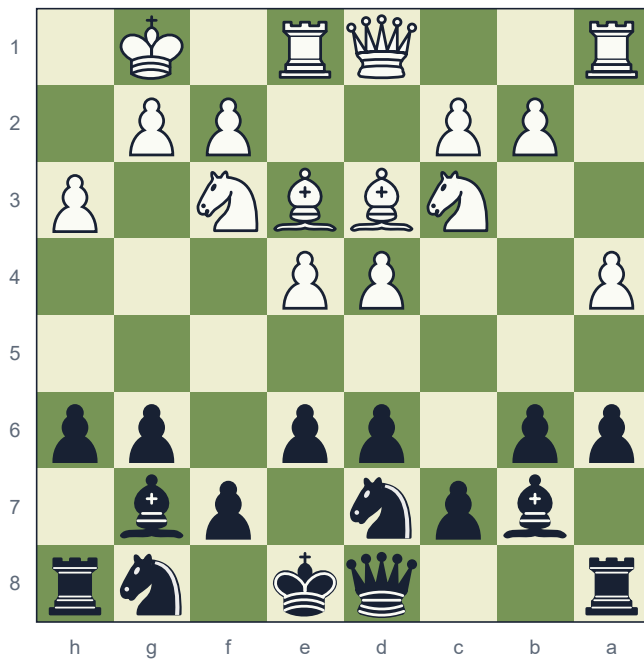
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HB-01 / The full formation as a study position

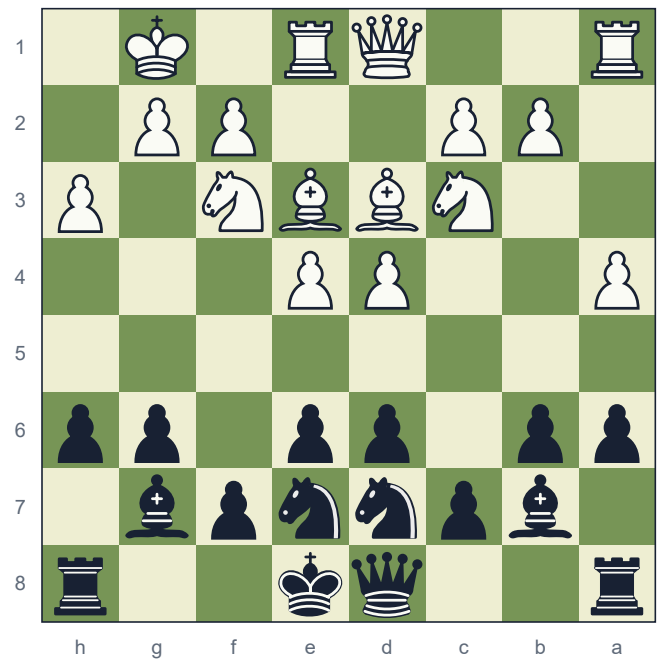
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 a6 5. Bd3 b6 6. O-O Bb7 7. Re1 e6 8. a4 Nd7 9. h3 h6 10. Be3 Ne7

The anchor is the complete printed sequence.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

This illustrative route shows the recognizable formation when White develops quietly. The knights avoid blocking the fianchetto bishops, but Black has used many pawn tempi and is still uncastled.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Decide on king safety and a central break. Examine ...c5 against d4 and ...d5 against e4; neither move is compulsory or safe in every version.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White owns more space and can prepare d5, e5 or a wing attack. Finishing the diagram is not a strategic achievement if Black then has no active move.

REMEMBER The formation is a starting point for decisions.

HB-02 / White chooses Be2

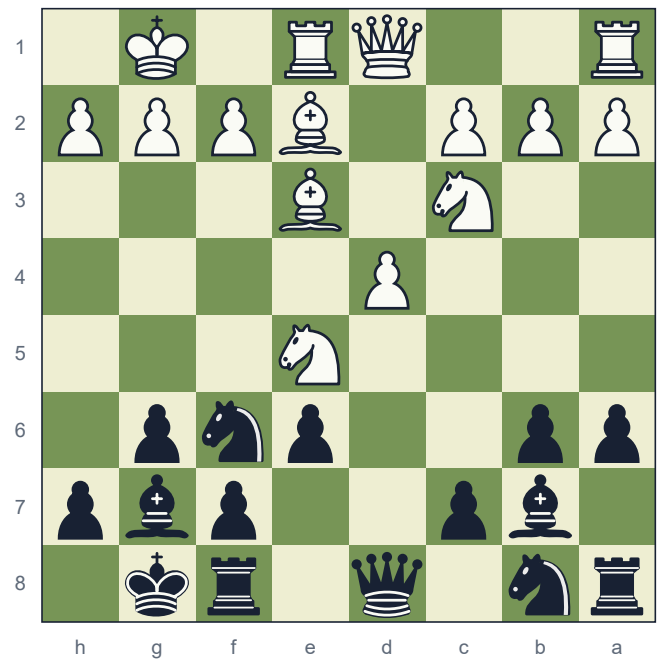
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 a6 5. Be2 b6 6. O-O Bb7 7. Re1 e6 8. Be3 Nf6 9. e5 dxe5 10. Nxe5 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 7... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The bishop on e2 is less directly aimed at h7 than on d3, but White can support a central advance without exposing pieces. Black preserves flexibility.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Nd7 and assess ...Ne7 or ...Nf6 from the actual center. If a central exchange opens a bishop diagonal, calculate it before making another wing pawn move.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may use Bf1, a4 and d5 to squeeze. A lack of immediate threats is not permission for unlimited waiting.

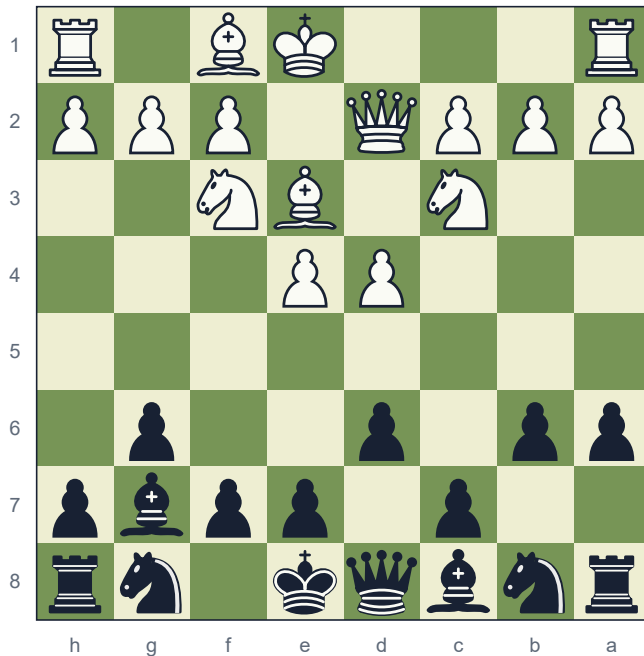
REMEMBER Quiet opponents can win by restricting every break.

HB-03 / White develops Be3 and Qd2

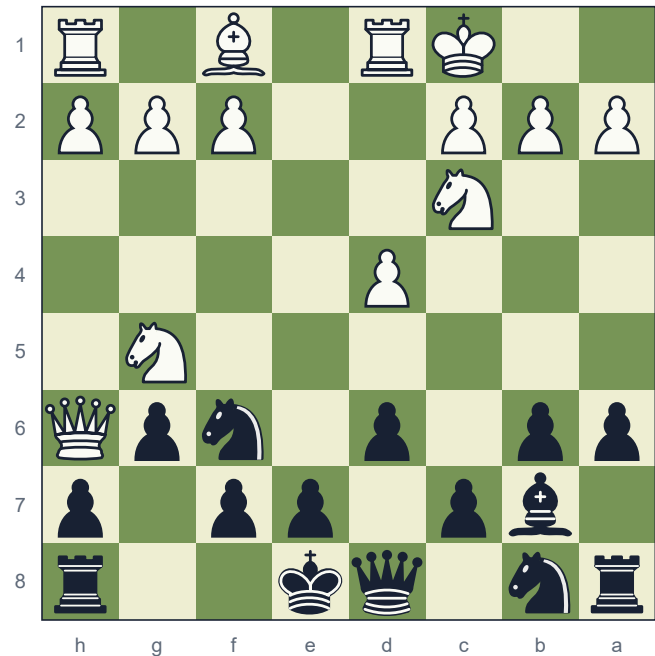
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 a6 5. Qd2 b6 6. Nf3 Bb7 7. O-O-O Nf6 8. Bh6 Bxh6 9. Qxh6 Bxe4 10. Ng5 Bb7

Authored anchor ends after 6... Bb7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White prepares flexible castling and may seek Bh6 to exchange the g7 bishop. Black must notice the attacking setup before automatically playing ...h6.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare ...e6 and ...Nd7 while choosing a safe king destination. If Bh6 is possible, decide whether to exchange, retreat or create central counterplay.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can castle long and push h4. Removing the fianchetto bishop may weaken dark squares around a castled black king.

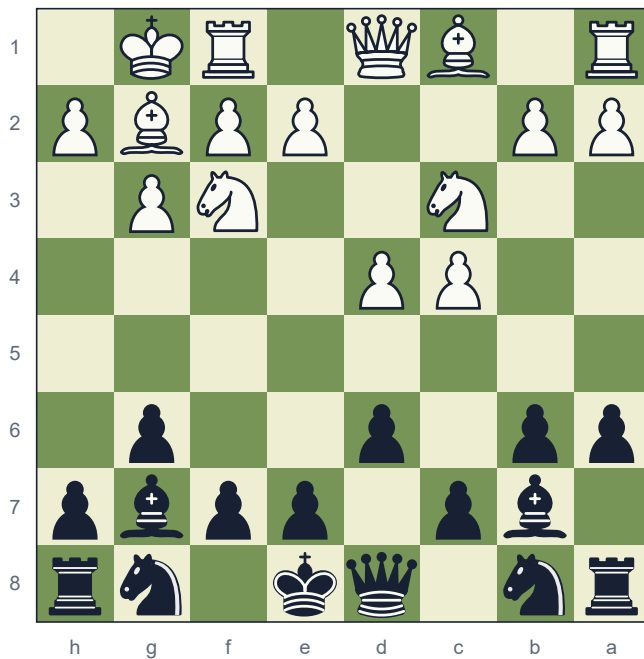
REMEMBER Identify the opponent's king choice before fixing yours.

HB-04 / White fianchettoes the king bishop

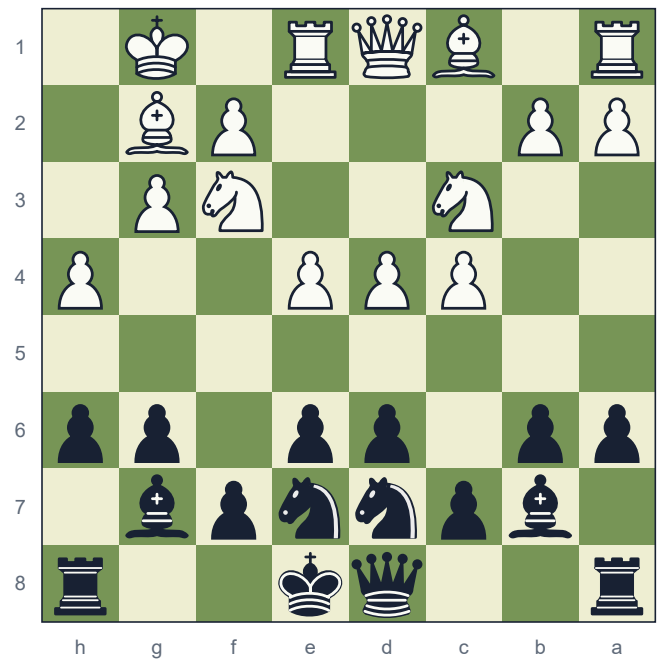
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nf3 d6 4. g3 a6 5. Bg2 b6 6. O-O Bb7 7. Nc3 e6 8. e4 Nd7 9. Re1 h6 10. h4 Ne7

Authored anchor ends after 7... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Both sides have long-diagonal bishops, but White has more central space. The g2 bishop creates pressure against b7 when the center opens.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop knights and prepare a break that releases your own bishops. Recount b7 and e4 pressure after each central pawn exchange.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can advance d5 or e4 with good support. A quiet fianchetto can still produce a strong squeeze.

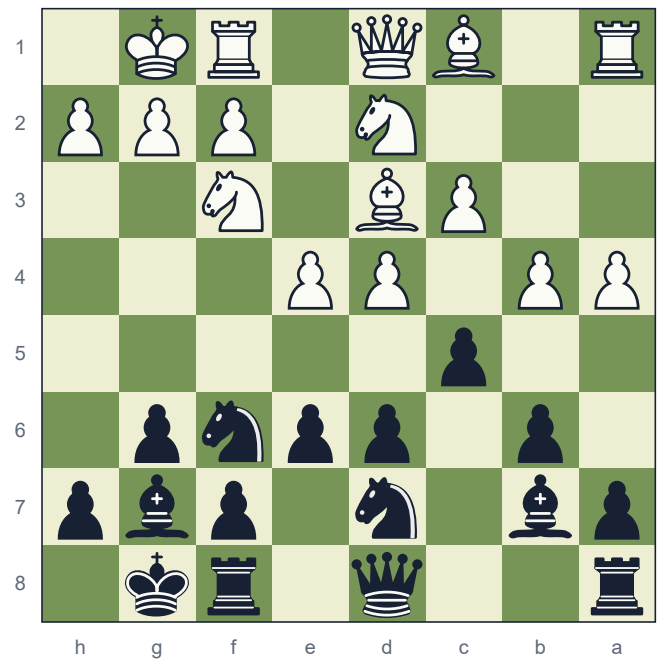
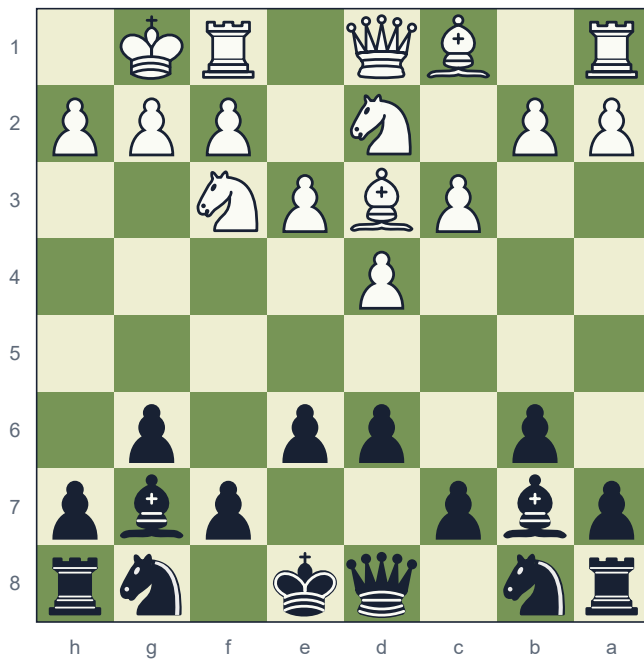
REMEMBER Opening a diagonal can activate both bishops.

HB-05 / White keeps the c-pawn on c2

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Bd3 b6 5. O-O Bb7 6. Nbd2 e6 7. c3 Nd7 8. e4 Ngf6 9. a4 O-O 10. b4 c5

Authored anchor ends after 7... Nd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

Without c4 White has less queenside space but a compact center. Black can develop flexibly and often challenge d4 with ...c5.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Decide whether the f8 knight belongs on e7 or f6. Prepare castling and use ...c5 when the resulting exchanges do not expose your king.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

e4 can suddenly build a broad center and threaten e5. The modest e3 setup may be a preparation rather than a permanent concession.

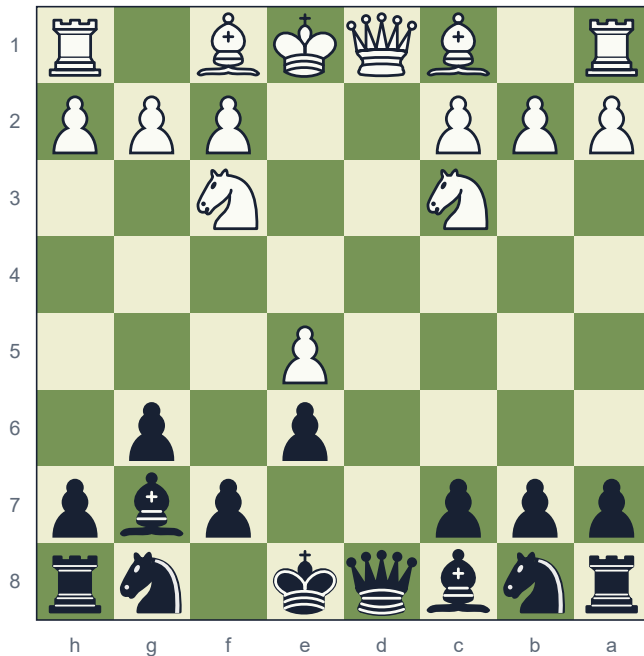
REMEMBER Watch the next central expansion, not only the current one.

HB-06 / An early queen exchange option

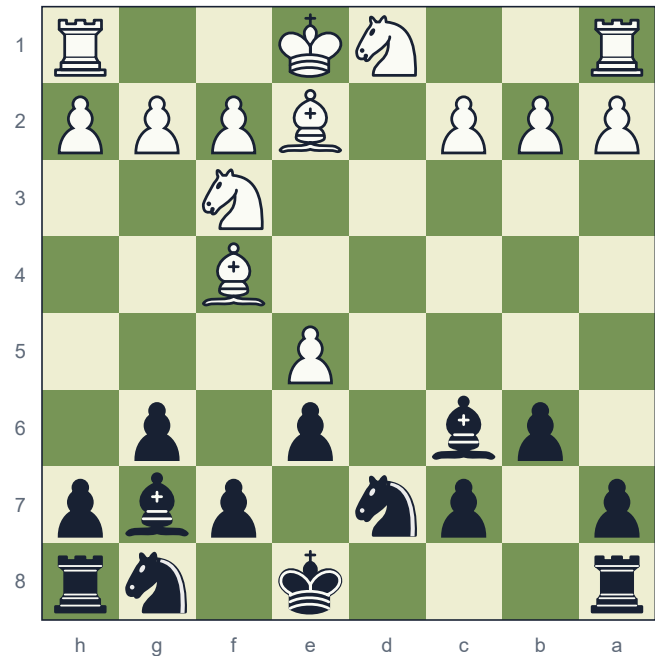
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. e5 dxe5 6. dxe5 Qxd1+ 7. Nxd1 b6 8. Bb5+ Bd7 9. Be2 Bc6 10. Bf4 Nd7

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nxd1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Central exchanges can open the d-file and permit a queen trade. Black is no longer building a full Hippo and should value development and king activity accordingly.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the pieces toward active squares and target the advanced e5 pawn if possible. Do not continue irrelevant wing pawn moves after the position has opened.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White retains space and can develop quickly. Queenless positions still punish undeveloped pieces and weak pawns.

REMEMBER Once the center opens, leave the formation mindset.

Work through HB-01

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

9... H6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

10... NE7

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

This illustrative route shows the recognizable formation when White develops quietly. The knights avoid blocking the fianchetto bishops, but Black has used many pawn tempi and is still uncastled. Decide on king safety and a central break. Examine ...c5 against d4 and ...d5 against e4; neither move is compulsory or safe in every version.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Large centers and early pawn attacks

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HB-07 - White occupies c4-d4-e4. Black chooses a partial formation and castles instead of insisting on both fianchettoes before addressing the center.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Prepare ...c5 or ...d5 with enough support. A bishop on b7 is useful only if its diagonal and the required tempi justify it.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White can gain more space with d5 or build a kingside attack with f4. Do not add ...a6 and ...h6 automatically under a development deficit.

RECOGNITION TEST

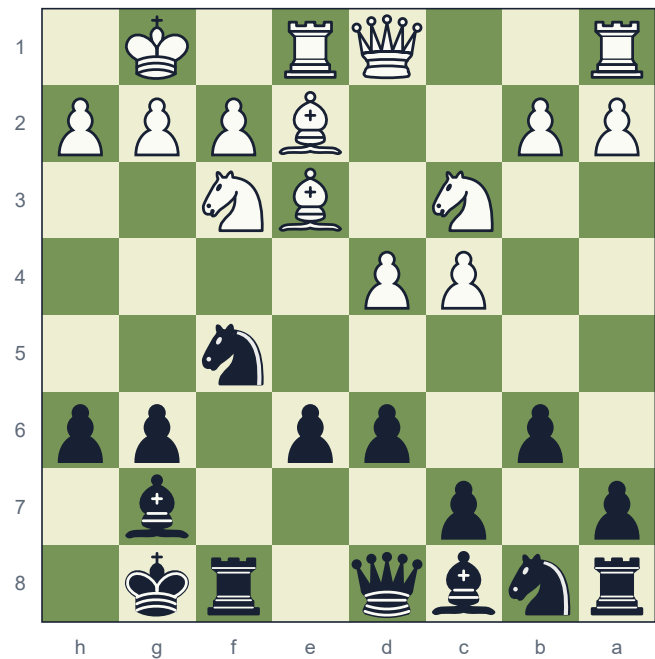
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HB-07 / The three-pawn center

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. c4 d6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 O-O 7. O-O h6 8. Re1 b6 9. Be3 f5 10. exf5 Nxf5

Authored anchor ends after 7. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White occupies c4-d4-e4. Black chooses a partial formation and castles instead of insisting on both fianchettoes before addressing the center.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Prepare ...c5 or ...d5 with enough support. A bishop on b7 is useful only if its diagonal and the required tempi justify it.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can gain more space with d5 or build a kingside attack with f4. Do not add ...a6 and ...h6 automatically under a development deficit.

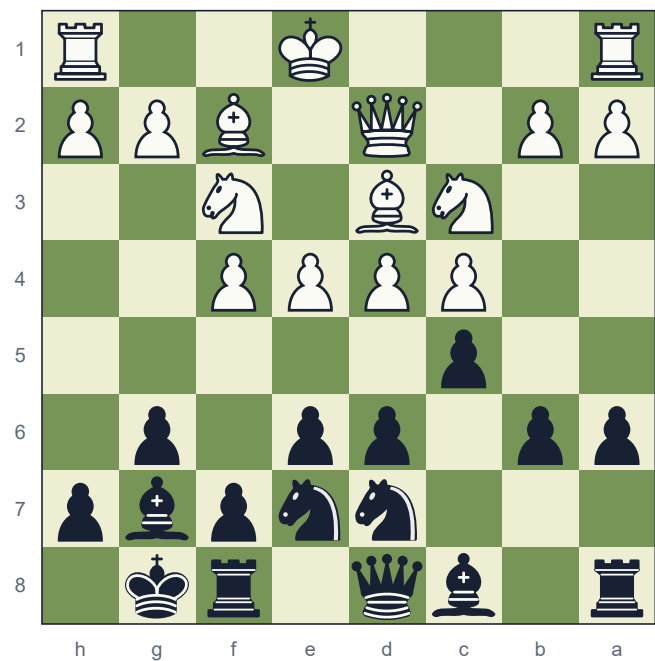
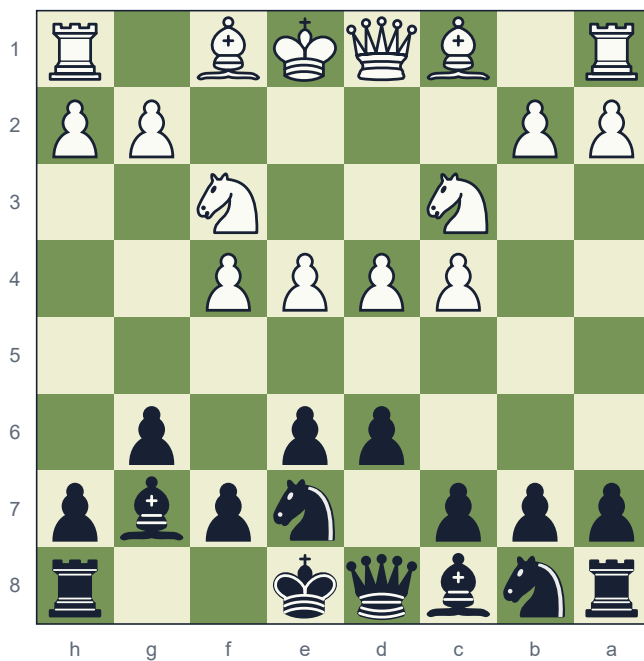
REMEMBER More opposing space demands earlier central action.

HB-08 / The four-pawn center

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. c4 d6 4. Nc3 e6 5. f4 Ne7 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be3 Nd7 8. Qd2 a6 9. Bf2 b6 10. Bd3 c5

Authored anchor ends after 6... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White adds f4 and may push e5 or f5. Black prioritizes development and king safety; a full Hippo is not the automatic answer.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Challenge the center with ...c5 when ready, then calculate d5 and exchanges. Keep pieces aimed at the pawn chain rather than retreating without a plan.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White's attack may become dangerous if allowed to consolidate every pawn. You need a break, not merely a compact-looking position.

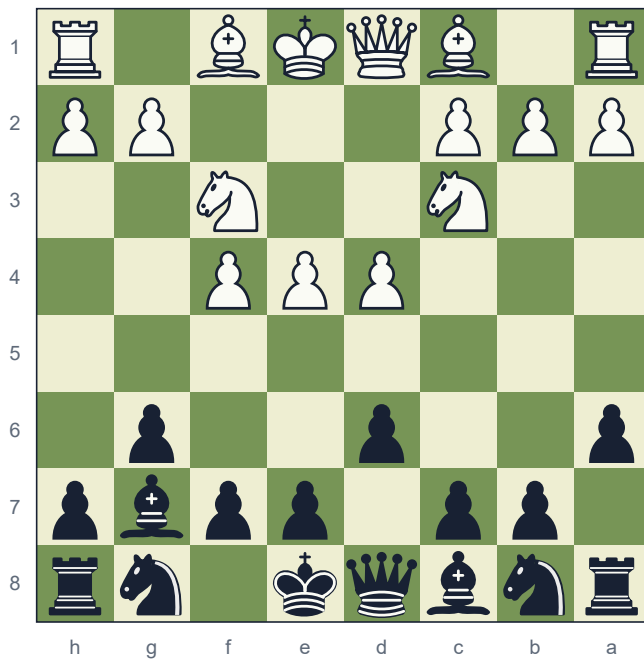
REMEMBER Against four pawns, finish development and challenge them.

HB-09 / The Austrian-style f4 center

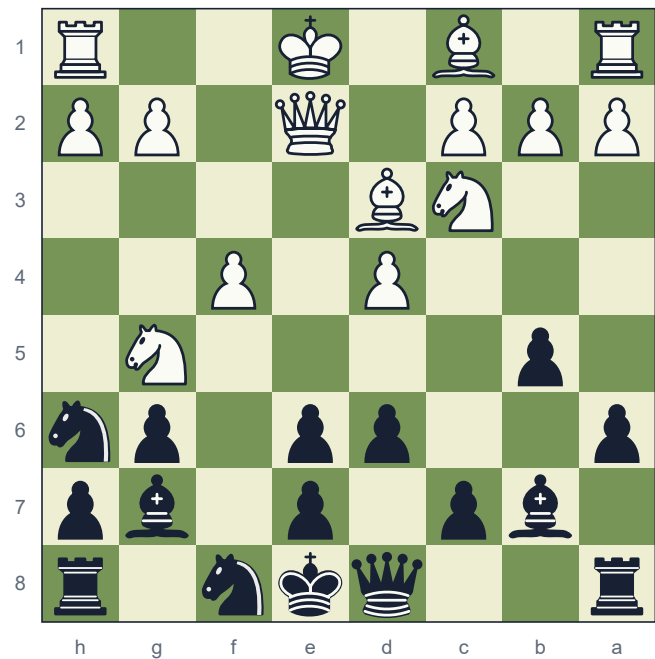
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 a6 5. Nf3 b5 6. Bd3 Bb7 7. Qe2 Nd7 8. e5 Nh6 9. e6 fxe6 10. Ng5 Nf8

Authored anchor ends after 5... b5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black uses a partial formation with immediate queenside activity. ...b5 aims for ...Bb7 and may question Nc3 with ...b4; it is a concrete response to White's central ambition.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishop and calculate e5 before each slow move. If the center opens, choose piece development and king safety over completing the usual pawn bank.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

e5 can arrive with tempo against Black's pieces. A queenside expansion does not excuse ignoring the central breakthrough.

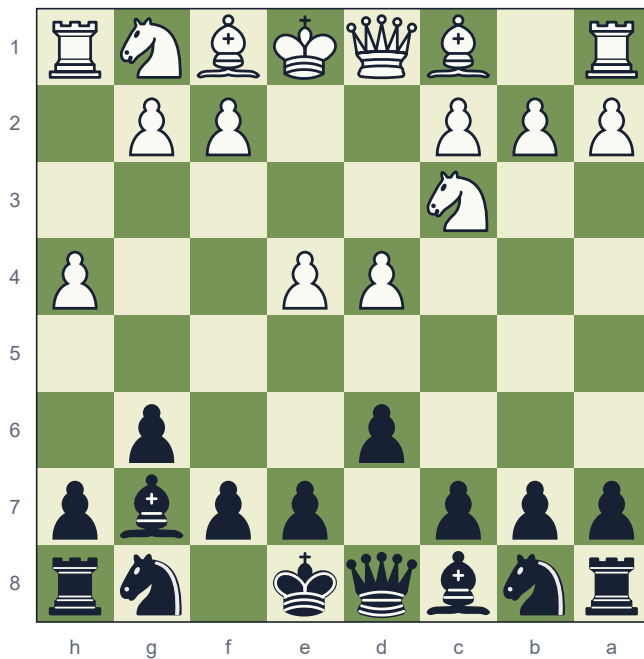
REMEMBER Counterplay must arrive before the center breaks open.

HB-10 / An immediate h-pawn attack

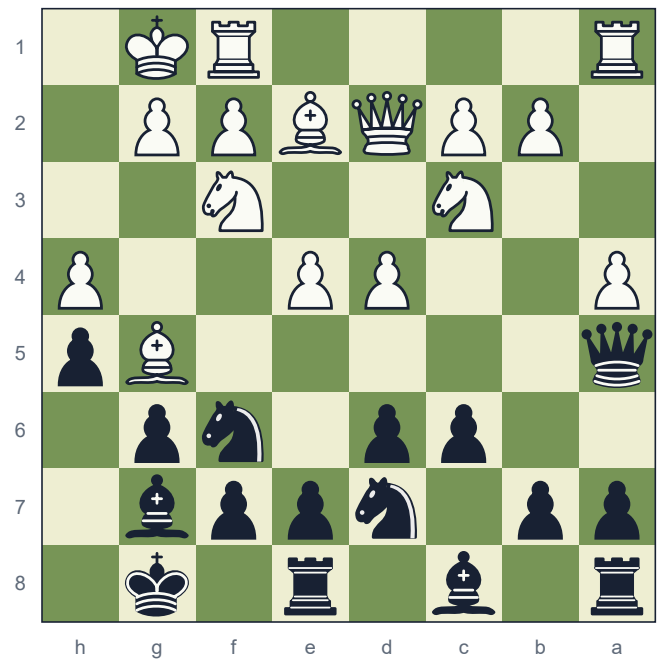
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. h4 h5 5. Bg5 Nf6 6. Qd2 c6 7. a4 Nbd7 8. Be2 Qa5 9. Nf3 O-O 10. O-O Re8

Authored anchor ends after 4... h5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

...h5 stops the immediate h4-h5 lever. Black accepts a fixed kingside structure rather than allowing White to open the h-file by force.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop while watching g4 and the central breaks. Keep the king flexible until you know whether the h-file will open.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

g4 can attack the new h5 hook. A blocked h-pawn does not mean the king side is permanently safe.

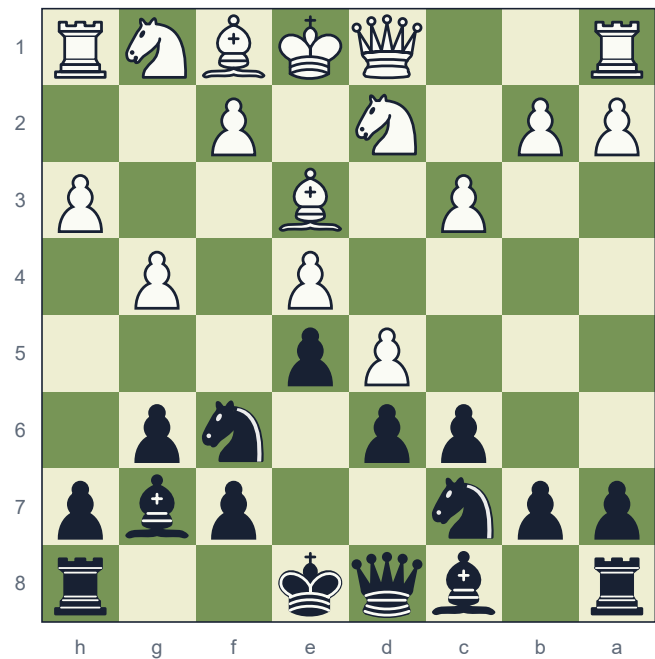
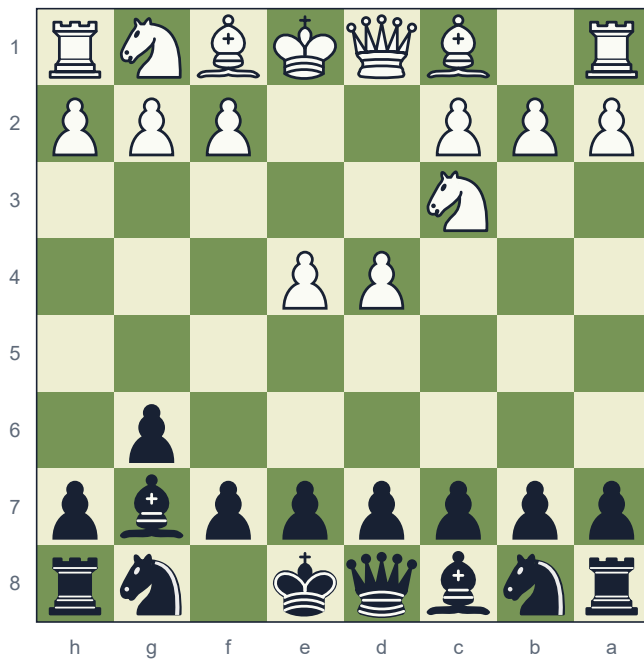
REMEMBER Stopping one lever creates a new contact to monitor.

HB-11 / White plays g4 early

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. g4 Nc6 5. d5 Nd4 6. h3 e5 7. Nb1 c6 8. c3 Nb5 9. Be3 Nf6 10. Nd2 Nc7

Authored anchor ends after 4. g4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White spends time on a wing attack before completing development. Black must calculate central action instead of reacting only on the attacked wing.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Examine ...c5 or ...h5, checking captures and king safety. Develop with threats when possible; the center is the natural place to test a premature wing expansion.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A careless ...h6 can provide the exact hook White wants. Do not complete a decorative pawn wall while the g-pawn advances.

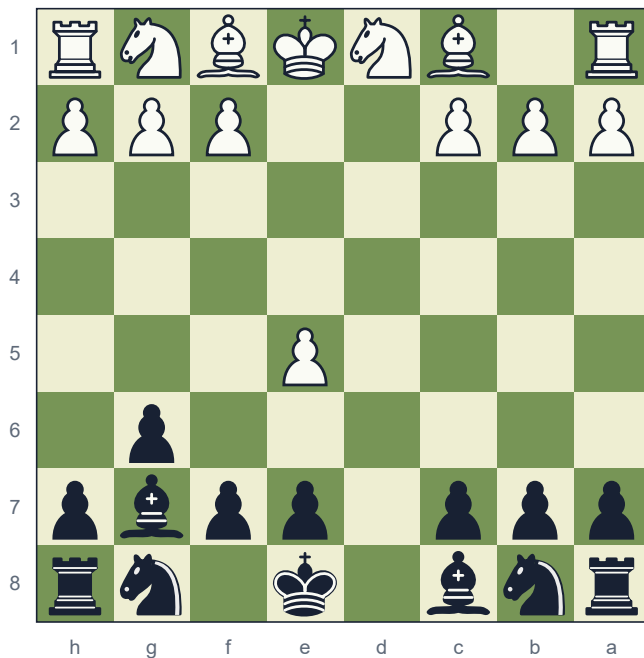
REMEMBER Counter a wing attack through the center when it is safe.

HB-12 / White advances e5 early

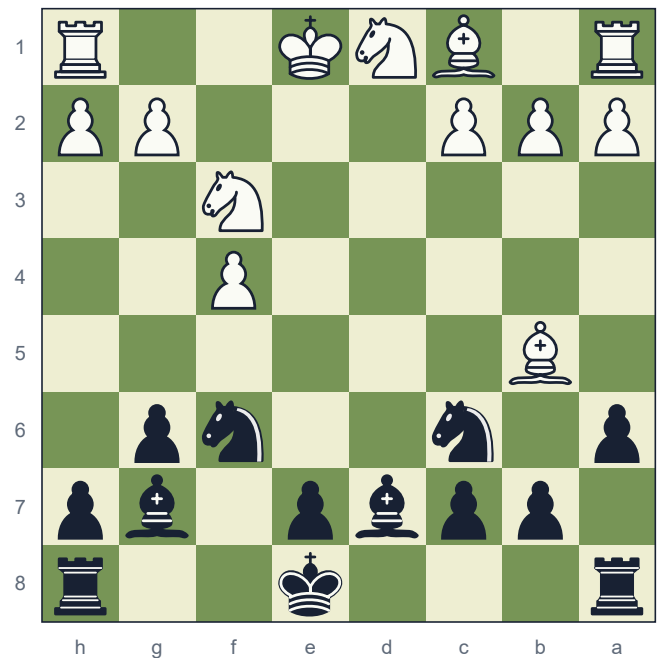
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e5 dxe5 5. dxe5 Qxd1+ 6. Nxd1 Nc6 7. f4 f6 8. Bb5 Bd7 9. exf6 Nxf6 10. Nf3 a6

Authored anchor ends after 6... Nc6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black opens the center and trades queens, then develops with pressure on e5. The immediate central decision takes precedence over any plan to double fianchetto.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop actively and coordinate pieces against e5. Compare a useful capture with a developing move instead of trying to recreate the original pawn structure.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can defend e5 and use the space advantage. A queen trade is a transition to a playable struggle, not proof that Black has won a pawn.

REMEMBER Respond to a central break immediately.

Work through HB-07

7... H6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

8... B6

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

9... F5

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

10... NXF5

The knight captures a pawn on f5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White occupies c4-d4-e4. Black chooses a partial formation and castles instead of insisting on both fianchettos before addressing the center. Prepare ...c5 or ...d5 with enough support. A bishop on b7 is useful only if its diagonal and the required tempi justify it.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Other first moves and positional systems

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HB-13 - White's bishop develops outside the pawn chain and may support e5. Black uses the double fianchetto while keeping the central break flexible.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop the king knight and decide between ...c5 and ...e5. Count the support of e5 before allowing a white knight or pawn there.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White can use Nbd2, c3 and e4 to expand. The London label does not guarantee that White will remain passive.

RECOGNITION TEST

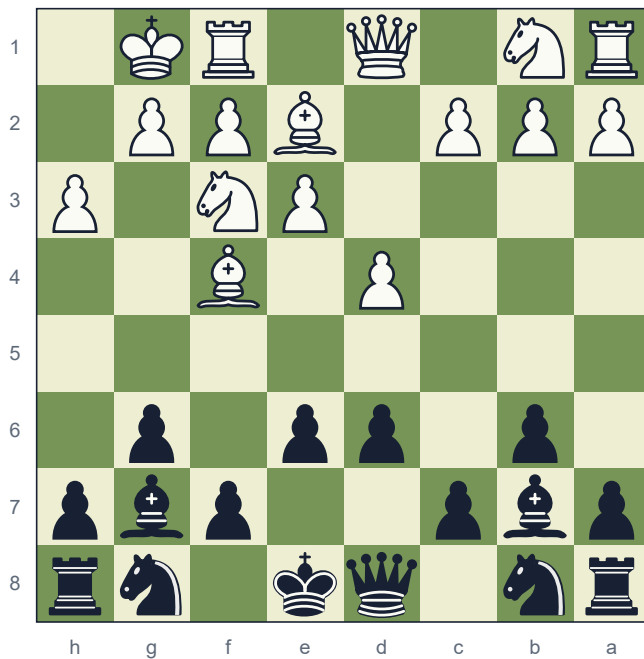
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HB-13 / Against the London bishop

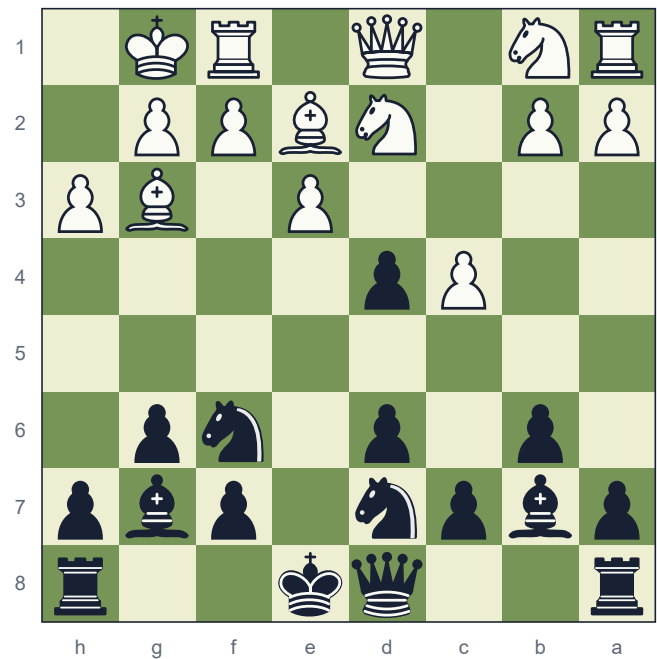
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. Bf4 d6 4. e3 b6 5. h3 Bb7 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Nd7 8. c4 Ngf6 9. Nfd2 e5 10. Bg3 exd4

Authored anchor ends after 7... Nd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White's bishop develops outside the pawn chain and may support e5. Black uses the double fianchetto while keeping the central break flexible.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the king knight and decide between ...c5 and ...e5. Count the support of e5 before allowing a white knight or pawn there.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can use Nbd2, c3 and e4 to expand. The London label does not guarantee that White will remain passive.

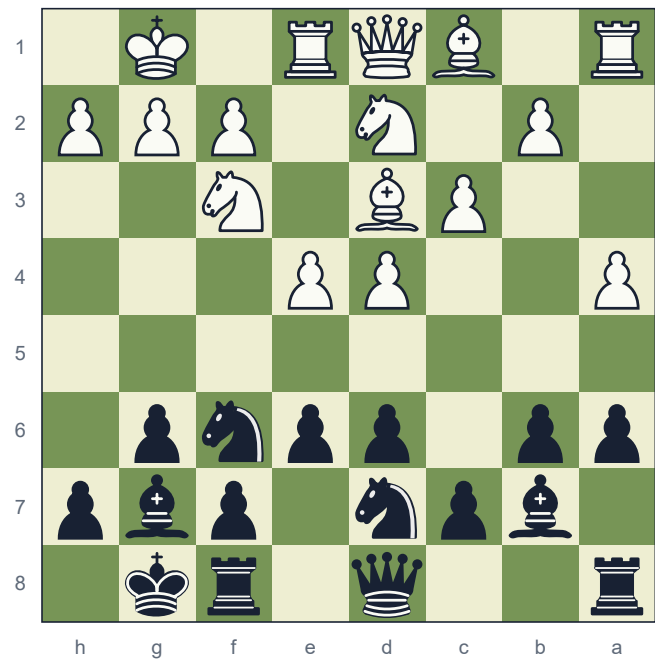
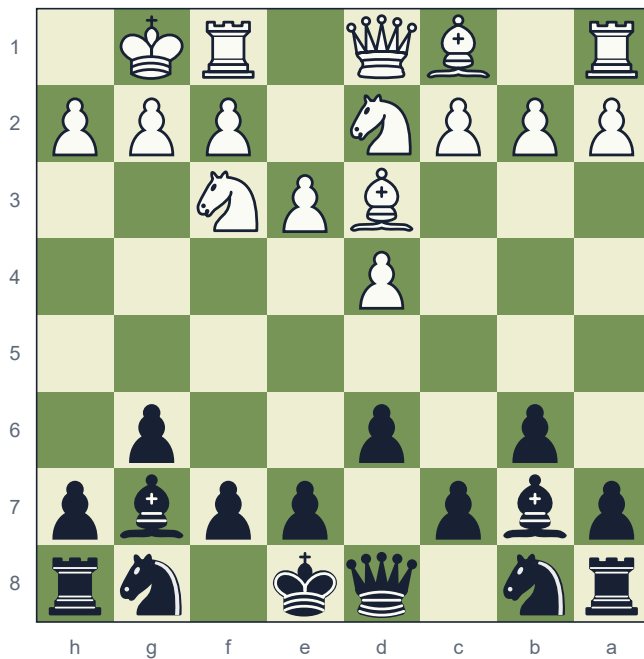
REMEMBER The bishop on f4 changes the e5 square.

HB-14 / Against the Colle structure

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Bd3 b6 5. O-O Bb7 6. Nbd2 e6 7. e4 Nf6 8. a4 a6 9. Re1 O-O 10. c3 Nbd7

Authored anchor ends after 7. e4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White has achieved e4 and threatens to gain more space. Black must reassess the center at once instead of treating the earlier e3 structure as unchanged.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider ...Ne7, ...Nd7 and a timely ...c5, checking e5. If a pawn exchange frees a bishop, compare that activity with the loss of central restraint.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

e5 can attack a developed knight or open attacking diagonals. White's bishop on d3 already aims toward the king side.

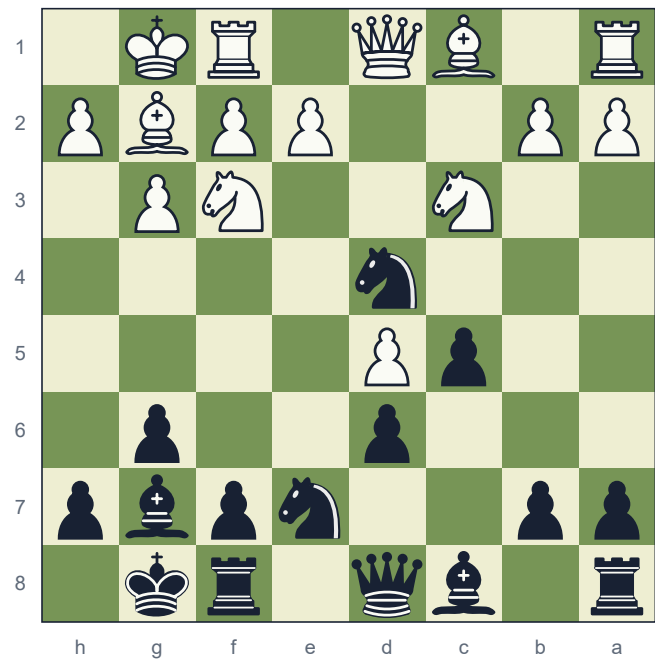
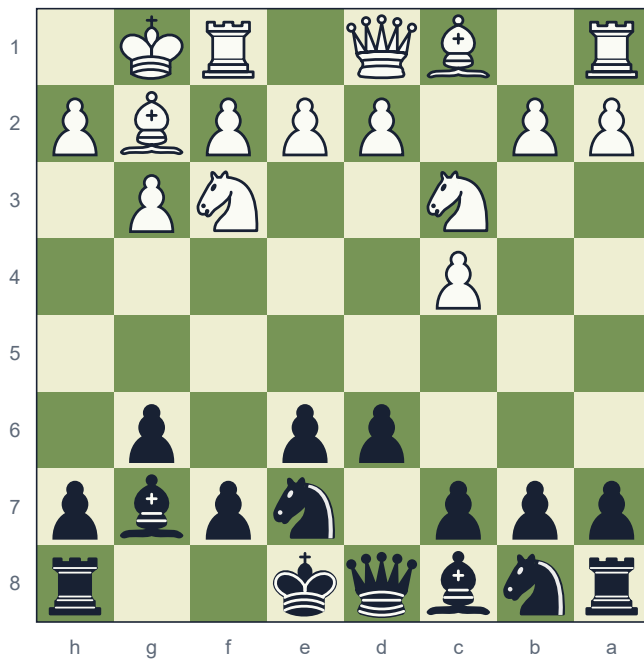
REMEMBER A prepared e4 changes the pace of the game.

HB-15 / Against the English Opening

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. d3 c5 8. d4 Nbc6 9. d5 exd5 10. cxd5 Nd4

Authored anchor ends after 7. d3. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White keeps d4 and e4 flexible. Black can choose a partial Hippo without spending time on both wing pawn pairs.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Decide whether ...c5 produces a useful symmetric structure or ...b6 adds meaningful diagonal pressure. Keep d5 under observation.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can choose d4 in one move and open the center quickly. A slow complete formation may allow a favorable central transformation for White.

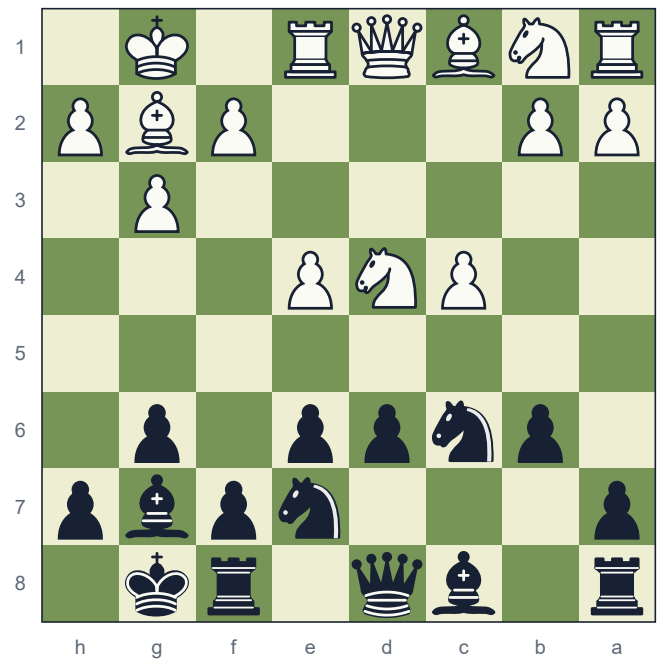
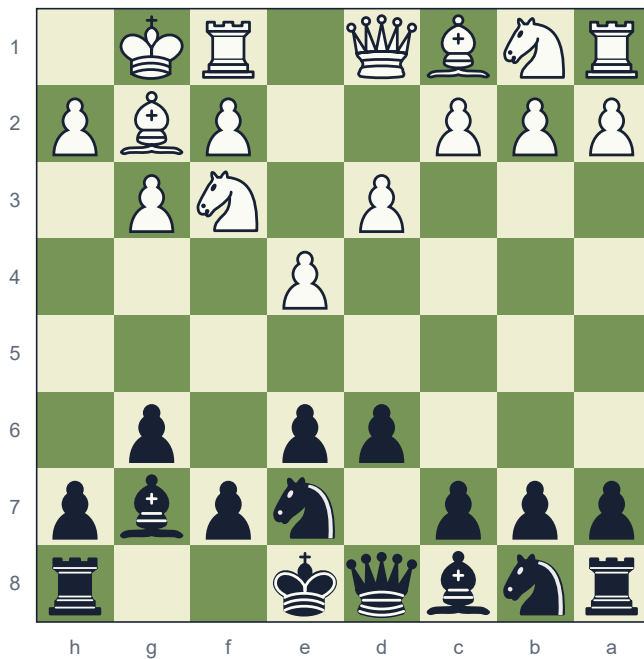
REMEMBER Flexible opposing pawns require flexible development.

HB-16 / Against the Reti

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. Nf3 g6 2. g3 Bg7 3. Bg2 d6 4. O-O e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. e4 b6 7. d4 O-O 8. Re1 c5 9. c4 cxd4 10. Nxd4 Nbc6

Authored anchor ends after 6... b6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

White adopts a King's Indian Attack shape. Black can double fianchetto but should watch whether e5 would gain space with a useful tempo.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Bb7 and ...Nd7, then choose a central break. If White remains restrained, improve pieces before deciding the king side.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may switch to c4 or e5 depending on Black's center. The system is not immune to a change of plan.

REMEMBER Expect the opponent to change structures.

HB-17 / Against the Bird

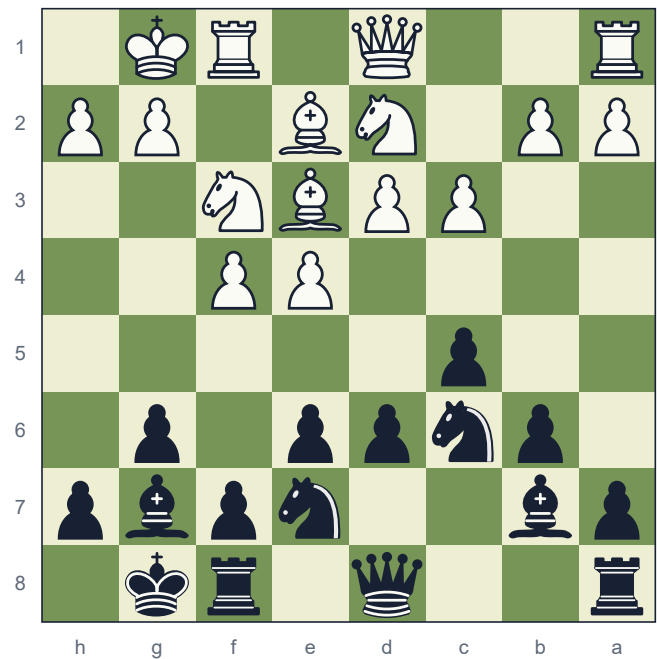
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. f4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. e3 d6 4. Be2 e6 5. O-O Ne7 6. d3 b6 7. c3 Bb7 8. e4 O-O 9. Be3 c5 10. Nbd2 Nbc6

Authored anchor ends after 6... b6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White's f-pawn gives kingside space but also changes the e3 and e4 squares. Black's g7 bishop can become useful against the long diagonal.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Bb7 and ...Nd7 while preparing ...c5 or ...e5. Calculate the capture on e5 if both sides contest it.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can push e4 and f5. Do not wait until every break has become difficult.

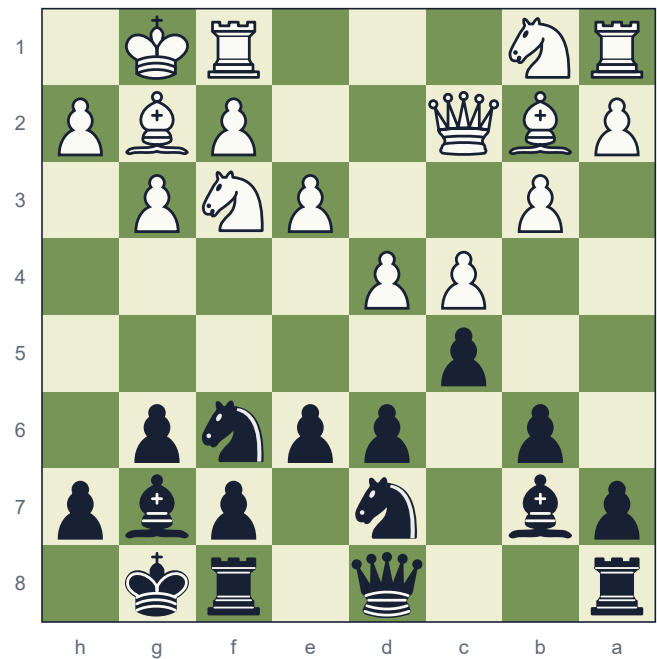
REMEMBER Identify which central square the f-pawn supports.

HB-18 / Against 1.b3

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. b3 g6 2. Bb2 Nf6 3. e3 Bg7 4. Nf3 d6 5. d4 e6 6. g3 b6 7. Bg2 Bb7 8. O-O O-O 9. c4 Nbd7 10. Qc2 c5

Authored anchor ends after 5... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

The bishop on b2 already attacks g7 along an open diagonal. Black first develops Nf6 to block that line before placing an undefended bishop on g7.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the queen side and choose a central break. This move order uses Nf6 instead of the standard Ne7 because a concrete threat determines the piece placement.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Playing ...Bg7 immediately after Bb2 would simply leave that bishop en prise. A normal-looking fianchetto is not safe in every move order.

REMEMBER Check the long diagonal before completing a fianchetto.

Work through HB-13

7... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

8... NGF6

Places the knight on f6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9... E5

Places the pawn on e5, attacking bishop on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10... EXD4

The pawn captures a pawn on d4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White's bishop develops outside the pawn chain and may support e5. Black uses the double fianchetto while keeping the central break flexible. Develop the king knight and decide between ...c5 and ...e5. Count the support of e5 before allowing a white knight or pawn there.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Pawn-break choices and partial formations

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

HB-19 - Black develops the queen knight before forcing a central break. In this exact position an immediate ...c5 allows strong white play; a thematic move still needs preparation.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Compare ...c5 and ...d5 on the next move after checking White's reply. If ...c5 becomes safe, calculate dxc5 and d5 separately and identify the opened file.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White can improve with Qd2 or advance in the center. Do not assume that a break becomes good simply because it belongs to the opening's vocabulary.

RECOGNITION TEST

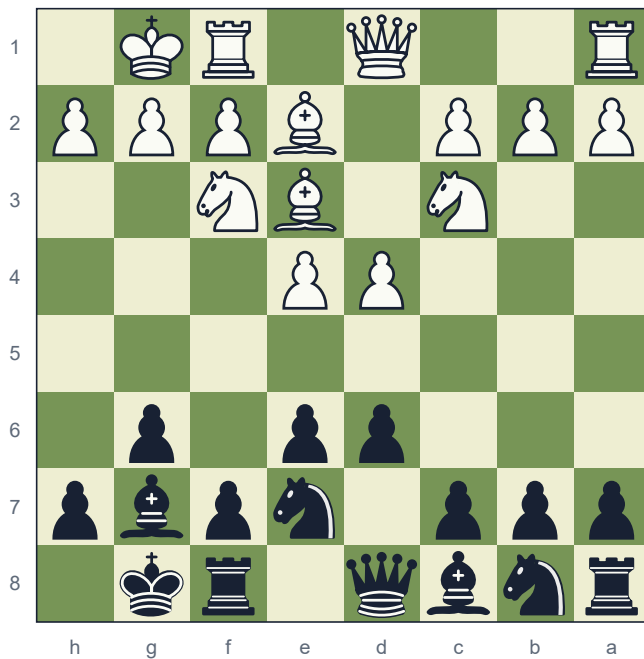
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

HB-19 / Prepare ...c5 with development

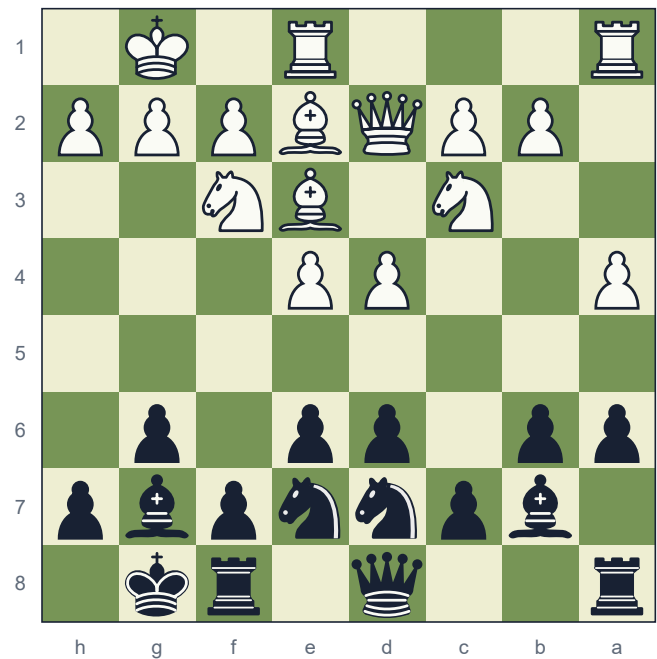
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Be2 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Be3 Nd7 8. Qd2 a6 9. a4 b6 10. Rfe1 Bb7

Authored anchor ends after 7... Nd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops the queen knight before forcing a central break. In this exact position an immediate ...c5 allows strong white play; a thematic move still needs preparation.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare ...c5 and ...d5 on the next move after checking White's reply. If ...c5 becomes safe, calculate dxc5 and d5 separately and identify the opened file.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can improve with Qd2 or advance in the center. Do not assume that a break becomes good simply because it belongs to the opening's vocabulary.

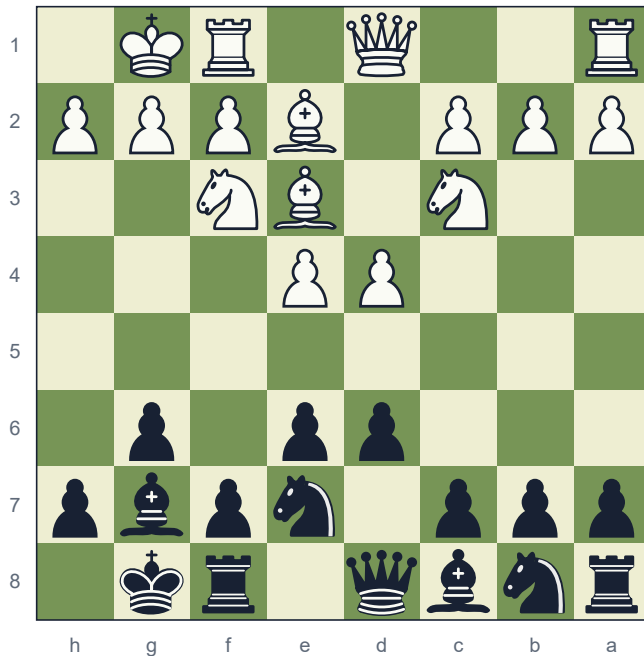
REMEMBER Prepare the break and calculate its consequences.

HB-20 / Use ...d5 to challenge e4

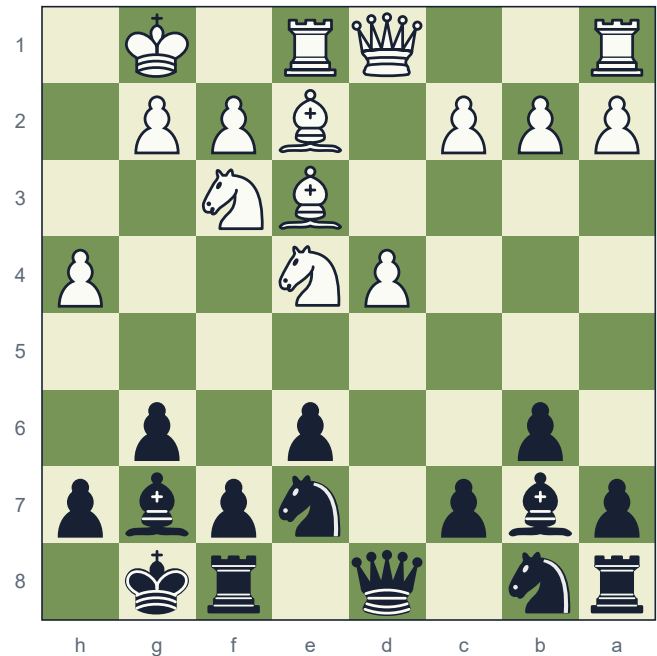
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. Be2 Ne7 6. O-O O-O 7. Be3 d5 8. Re1 dxe4 9. Nxe4 b6 10. h4 Bb7

Authored anchor ends after 7... d5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

...d5 directly challenges e4 but creates a new pawn contact and can be captured. Black chooses activity instead of preserving the original d6-e6 shell.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Compare exd5 and e5, including the effect on the bishops. Reposition pieces toward the opened files instead of clinging to their original squares.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A premature ...d5 can leave a weak isolated pawn or open lines before development is ready. Calculate all forcing replies.

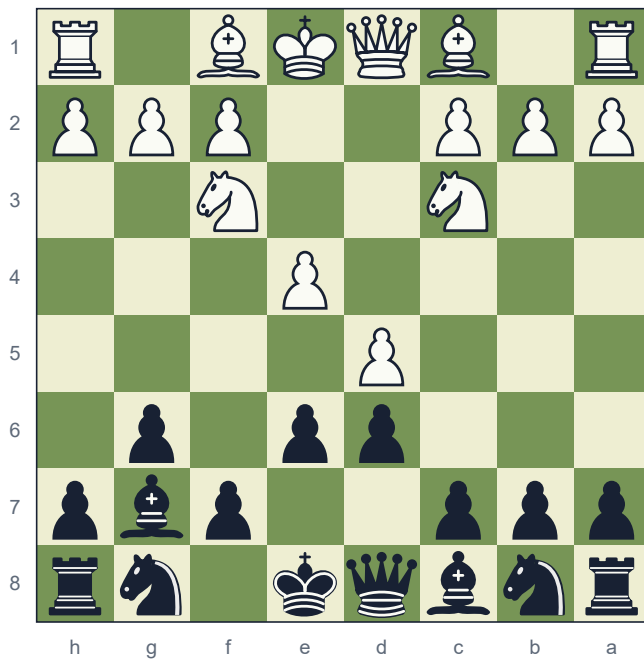
REMEMBER A central break is a concrete transformation, not a slogan.

HB-21 / White closes with d5

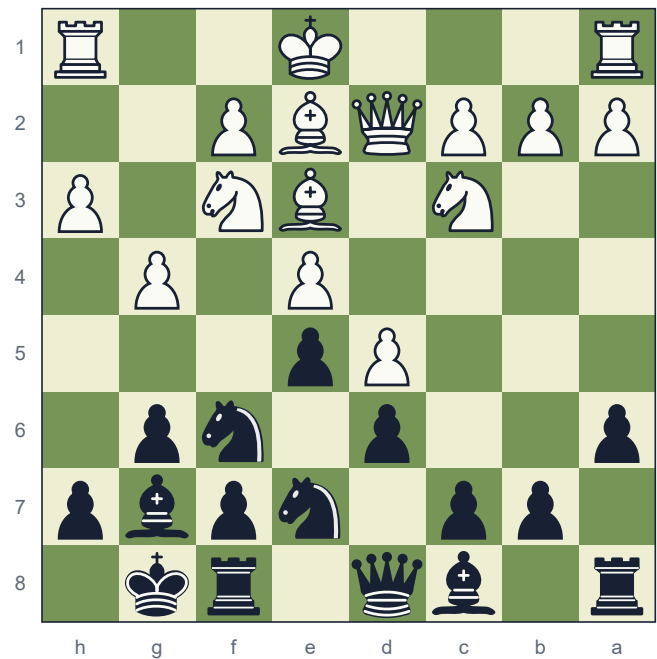
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. d5 e5 6. Be2 Ne7 7. Be3 Nd7 8. g4 Nf6 9. h3 O-O 10. Qd2 a6

Authored anchor ends after 5... e5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black meets d5 with ...e5 and closes the center. This gives a clear pawn-chain structure but also restricts the g7 bishop.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Consider a later ...f5 after preparation or queenside play with ...c6. Choose the wing based on the pawn chain and king safety.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can expand with c4 and b4 or attack on the king side. A blocked center gives maneuvering time, not unlimited time.

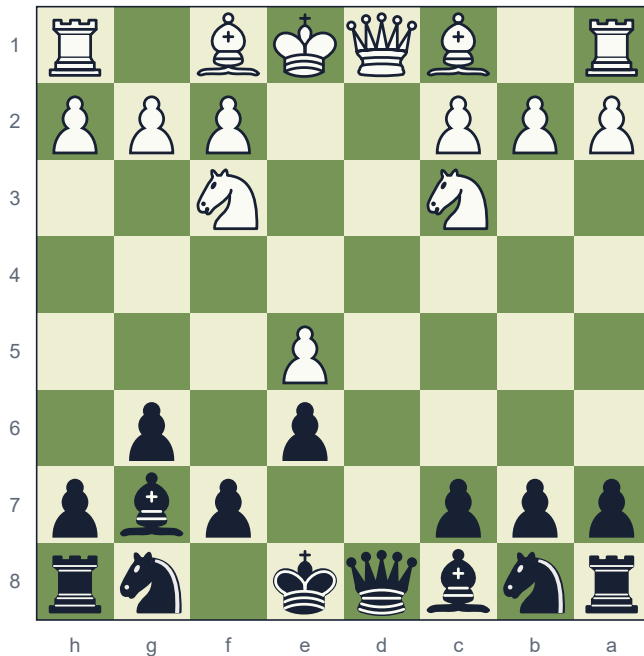
REMEMBER A closed bishop needs a future pawn break.

HB-22 / Meet the e5 advance by exchanging

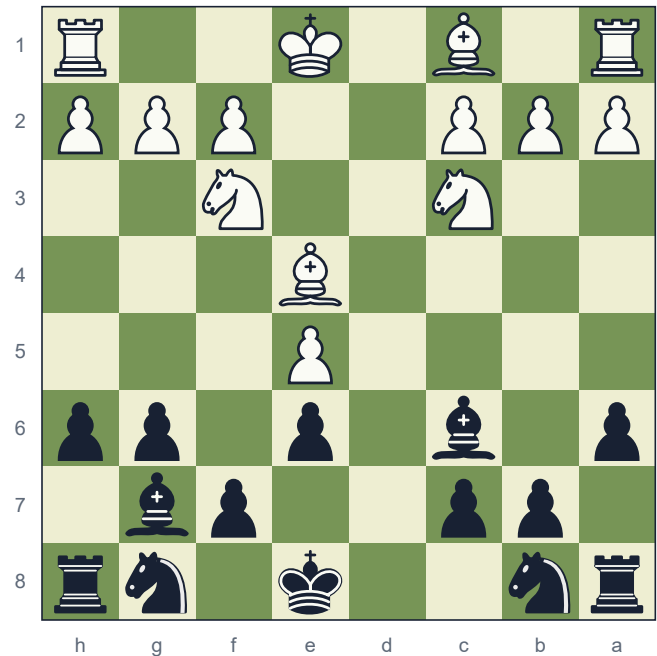
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e6 5. e5 dxe5 6. dxe5 Qxd1+ 7. Nxd1 Bd7 8. Nc3 a6 9. Bd3 Bc6 10. Be4 h6

Authored anchor ends after 7. Nxd1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black exchanges the advanced pawn and uses the open d-file to trade queens. In this exact move order, blocking with ...d5 gives White a stronger bind and attacking chances.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop actively and challenge e5 with pieces. King activity and pawn targets now matter more than recreating the full Hippo formation.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White retains space and can consolidate the advanced pawn. A queen trade changes the type of struggle rather than ending it.

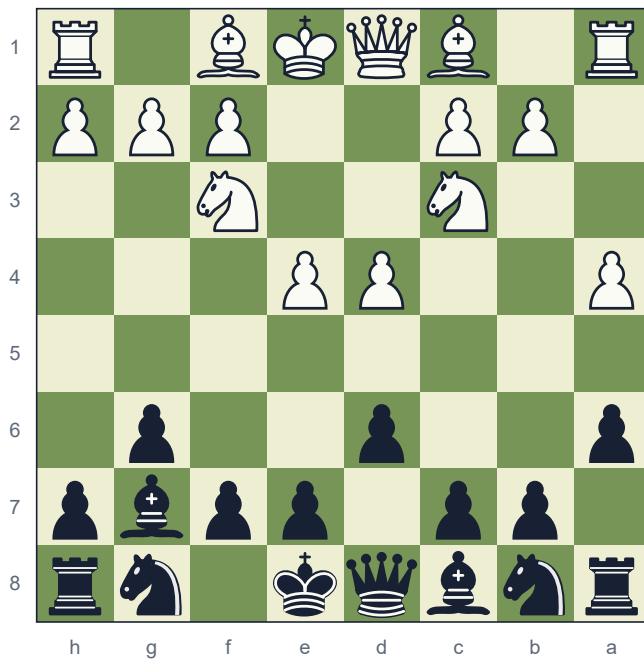
REMEMBER Compare blocking with exchanging before fixing the center.

HB-23 / A queenside space grab with a4

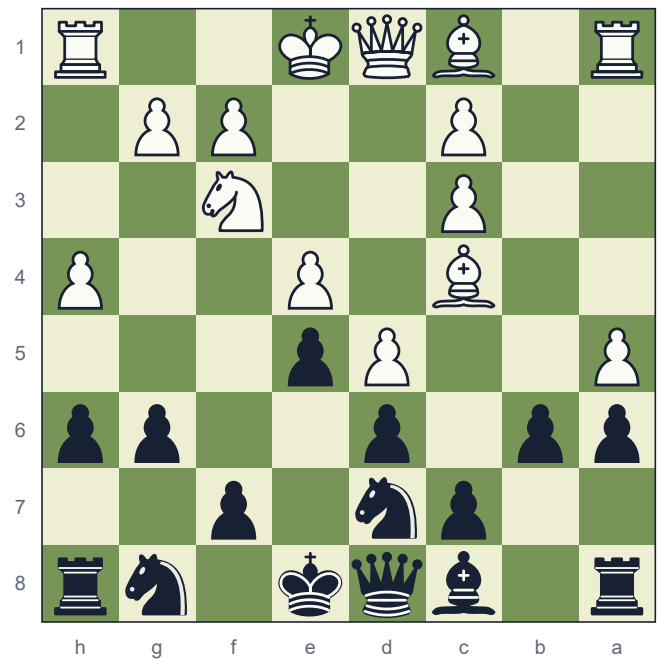
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 a6 5. a4 b6 6. Bc4 e6 7. h4 h6 8. d5 Bxc3+ 9. bxc3 e5 10. a5 Nd7

Authored anchor ends after 5... b6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White restrains ...b5. Black can still develop the bishop through b7, but should not force the pawn advance through a well-controlled square.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop centrally and choose ...c5 or ...d5 when safe. Reconsider whether ...a6 is useful in the resulting structure.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may use a5 to fix queenside weaknesses. A pawn move intended as flexibility can become a target.

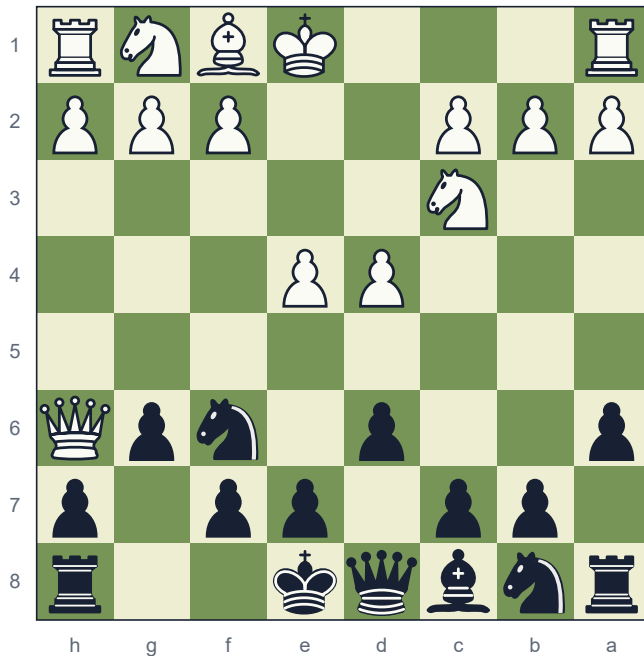
REMEMBER If a break is restrained, choose another useful plan.

HB-24 / White tries Bh6

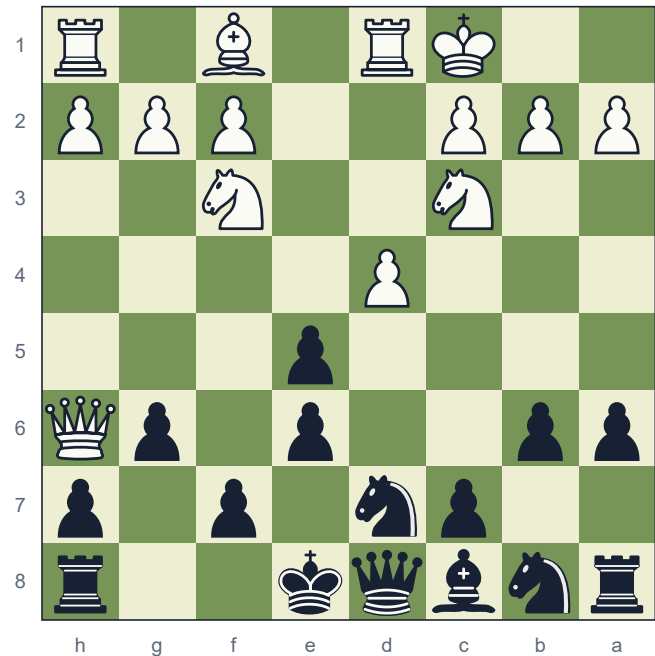
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Be3 a6 5. Qd2 Nf6 6. Bh6 Bxh6 7. Qxh6 b6 8. e5 Nfd7 9. Nf3 e6 10. O-O-O dxe5

Authored anchor ends after 7... b6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops Nf6 before this bishop-exchange sequence. White removes the fianchetto bishop and places the queen near the king side, creating a real dark-square concern.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop with attention to king safety and central counterplay. Choose the king's destination from the concrete threats instead of castling automatically toward the queen.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

If the black knight were still on g8, Qxh6 would lose the queen to ...Nxh6. The developed knight is an essential detail in this line.

REMEMBER Check the knight's square before a queen recapture.

Work through HB-19

7... ND7

Develops a knight toward central supporting squares. Keep a useful onward route so the compact setup does not become overcrowded.

8... A6

Controls nearby wing squares and may restrain a piece or pawn. Compare this useful purpose with the time lost to central development.

9... B6

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

10... BB7

Completes the queenside fianchetto and points toward e4. Count the diagonal's blockers before claiming immediate pressure.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black develops the queen knight before forcing a central break. In this exact position an immediate ...c5 allows strong white play; a thematic move still needs preparation. Compare ...c5 and ...d5 on the next move after checking White's reply. If ...c5 becomes safe, calculate dxc5 and d5 separately and identify the opened file.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.